

Information Manipulation and Hate Speech Causing Real-World Harm to Ordinary Africans

Prepared for: ITWeb Security Summit 2026 — Johannesburg Keynote Research

Sources: attached PDF files (Cunliffe-Jones incident database, Shiundu/Disinformation in Africa chapter, Disinformation and Peacebuilding in Sub-Saharan Africa, Perlego book chapters) + independent research

Executive Summary

This report catalogues the types of information manipulation, disinformation, and hate speech that cause the most severe physical, economic, or psychological harm to ordinary Africans — individuals and communities rather than elites, governments, or corporations. Eight primary harm categories are identified, each with documented examples of deaths, violence, economic loss, or lasting psychological injury. The most lethal category globally and across Africa is health-related disinformation — particularly fake miracle cures, anti-vaccine narratives, and supernatural disease rumours — followed closely by conflict-amplifying rumours, and xenophobic hate speech. South Africa presents a distinctive harm profile dominated by xenophobic disinformation and financial fraud, though faith-based health disinformation poses a serious secondary threat. A unifying finding across all categories is that the pathway from false information to real harm is dramatically shorter in Africa than elsewhere, due to weak institutions, low media literacy, digital infrastructure gaps, and the transition of false narratives from social media to radio and word-of-mouth — a cross-platform "jump" that multiplies reach into offline communities that cannot fact-check in real time.

Framing: Why Africa Is Disproportionately Harmed

Before examining specific harm categories, it is important to understand the structural conditions that make ordinary Africans especially vulnerable to information manipulation.

Only about 38% of Africa's population uses the internet, compared to a global average of 68%. This paradox — limited connectivity but high vulnerability — arises because content originates online and is then amplified through radio, community word-of-mouth, and religious gatherings, reaching large offline populations without any filtering. Africa Check founder Peter Cunliffe-Jones has characterised this as disinformation moving "from church and mosque to WhatsApp". Religious leaders, political figures, and local community voices carry enormous epistemic authority in societies where institutional trust in government and mainstream media is low. When those trusted voices amplify false narratives, the persuasive power is formidable.^{[1][2]}

Poverty acts as a force multiplier: it deprives people of the electricity, smartphones, and data connections needed to verify information, while simultaneously making them targets for

scammers exploiting economic desperation. Low digital and media literacy among newly connected populations means content is accepted without critical scrutiny. As Sammy Mupfunu of CongoCheck has noted, "information from both social media and traditional sources is often accepted as true without critical scrutiny".^{[2][1]}

The Cunliffe-Jones incident database analysed in the attached files provides a sample of fact-checked harmful claims. The most damaging incidents involved mob violence triggered by false organ-harvesting claims, misattributed footage of inter-ethnic violence, fake job advertisements enabling identity theft, and religiously amplified health falsehoods. These categories align well with broader research, though they are subject to selection bias toward anglophone, internet-accessible incidents.^[^3]

Harm Category 1: Health Disinformation — The Most Lethal Category

1.1 Fake Cures, Miracle Remedies, and Religious Healing Claims

Nature of harm: Deaths from treatment abandonment or poisoning; psychological harm from exploitation of the sick

This is almost certainly the single largest category of fatal harm from disinformation in Africa. It operates through two reinforcing mechanisms: false claims that untested remedies cure serious illness, and false claims — often made by religious figures — that prayer or "blessed water" alone constitutes a cure.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, traditional healers across Cameroon, the DRC, and Tanzania reported surges of hundreds of patients seeking herbal alternatives after social media circulated claims that conventional medicine had "no cure". Madagascar's President Andry Rajoelina's promotion of COVID-Organics — a herbal artemisia drink distributed to at least four other African countries — without clinical trials illustrates how state and quasi-state actors can weaponise health misinformation at scale. In the DRC, three children died after their mother gave them a social media-prescribed concoction she believed would protect against COVID-19. WHO cautioned explicitly that "misinformation, especially on social media, about the effectiveness of certain remedies" posed acute public health risks.^{[4][5][^1]}

The Pentecostal miracle healing economy presents a particularly well-documented danger. In Nairobi, an average of 10 people per month were documented to have stopped antiretroviral (ARV) therapy for HIV after pastors declared them miraculously cured and burned their medication. Countrywide in Kenya, INERELA+ (an international religious health network) recorded 2,000 such cases. In Malawi — where 990,000 people live with HIV and 13,000 die annually from AIDS — a growing number of HIV-positive people have reportedly abandoned ARV treatment in favour of New Pentecostal faith healers, with some churches explicitly expelling members who visit hospitals. Research among Pentecostal pastors in Cape Town found that some actively discouraged congregants from adhering to ART, framing HIV as a "demon" rather than a manageable medical condition.^{[6][7][8][9]}

South Africa specific: Despite being a middle-income country with a functioning health system, South Africa has an estimated 7.8 million people living with HIV and high rates of

engagement with Pentecostal and "apostolic" churches. There is documented evidence of pastors pressuring HIV-positive congregants — including children — to stop ARV therapy. Women who breastfeed while HIV-positive risk mother-to-child transmission; some were recorded refusing the drugs that would prevent this transmission. South Africa has 61% of the global burden of AIDS-related deaths in sub-Saharan Africa falling on the region.^{[10][11]}

1.2 Disease Rumours Triggering Mob Violence Against Health Workers

Nature of harm: Deaths of health workers; collapse of healthcare access in affected communities

One of the most dramatic recent examples of fatal health disinformation occurred in Tshopo province, northeastern DRC, in October 2025. Rumours spread — initially through Facebook, TikTok, churches, and local media — claiming that a mysterious disease was causing genital atrophy in men. The Africa Infodemic Response Alliance (IRA), a WHO-backed body, linked at least 17 deaths to this single rumour, including four health workers conducting *unrelated vaccine research* who were killed by mobs believing they were secretly spreading the fake disease. Reuters confirmed that one health worker, Dr. John Tangakara, was burned alive by the attackers. As the IRA director Elodie Ho stated: "In Congo, misinformation truly led to death and murder. It originated within communities, spread through social media and local media, and was amplified by various actors". The IRA hotline, launched in late 2024, surged from 3,000 to over 31,000 calls within a year. The WHO noted that similar violence had been linked to attacks on health workers in Mozambique and Malawi.^{[12][13][14]}

This pattern of rumour-driven attacks on health workers has been documented repeatedly in the context of Ebola response. False claims in the DRC accused vaccination teams of spreading Ebola rather than preventing it, leading to attacks on treatment centres and driving communities to hide cases. Measles cases surged by over 25% in conflict-affected regions in 2025, partly driven by vaccine misinformation that compounded healthcare disruption.^{[15][3]}

1.3 Anti-Vaccine Disinformation

Nature of harm: Preventable deaths from measles, polio, Ebola; community-level herd immunity collapse

Anti-vaccine disinformation is widespread across the continent and carries deep roots in colonial-era medical abuses. The most persistent false narrative frames mass vaccination as a Western population-control tool — a claim that resonates because of historical abuses and is amplified by foreign disinformation actors. In Nigeria, ongoing conflict has been compounded by entrenched vaccine mistrust and disinformation campaigns, resulting in "some of the highest rates of under-vaccinated children globally" according to the UN. Measles has surged as a result, with Nigeria accounting for a major share of the 74,340 measles cases reported in 18 conflict-affected countries in 2025. In the DRC, false claims that a Rwanda-developed Ebola vaccine was deliberately killing Congolese people triggered attacks on vaccination teams and contributed to reduced vaccine uptake. The Cunliffe-Jones database rates this as high-harm with documented links to health worker attacks and deteriorating public health.^{[1][3][15]}

Harm Category 2: Conflict-Triggering Rumours and Inter-Communal Hate Speech

2.1 False Videos and Images Attributed to the Wrong Communities

Nature of harm: Deaths, reprisal violence, community displacement

A consistent and well-documented mechanism for triggering inter-communal violence is the recycling of real footage from one event, relabelled as evidence of atrocities by a different ethnic or community group. Jamie Hitchen (University of Birmingham) describes this plainly: "Videos depicting attacks between individuals or ethnic groups can rapidly incite reprisal violence before any fact-checking response is possible". In the DRC, videos falsely attributed attacks to specific ethnic groups, deepening the M23 conflict. In North Kivu, a 24-year-old former combatant explained: "When I joined the movement, I was told I was defending my community against invaders. On WhatsApp, I saw videos showing massacres supposedly committed by the enemy. But once I was in the field, I realised that it wasn't all true. We were attacking villages where the people were innocent".^[16]^[2]

In Côte d'Ivoire, following the 2020 presidential election, fake claims of ethnic killings circulated on Twitter and other platforms following protests in a Malinke area. Six people died and approximately 40 were injured in clashes directly linked to the false rumours. In Rwanda and its neighbouring countries, politicians misuse historical narratives during elections, damaging relationships and inciting violence through disinformation spread via social media platforms.^[^2]

In South Sudan, false reports of ethnic attacks have triggered real retaliatory violence: "A viral message, amplified through social media, claimed that a community was under siege. Within hours, violence erupted — fuelled not by an actual threat but by a rumour that spread faster than any government response could contain".^[^17]

The Cunliffe-Jones database contains a specific example: a video falsely showing foreigners/Nigerians burned alive in South African xenophobic violence was actually footage from a Tanzanian tanker explosion, deliberately mislabelled by a Ghanaian junk news site for click revenue. The false video caused real damage to inter-ethnic relations and was linked to actual violence against South Africans.^[^3]

2.2 Ethno-Religious Disinformation in Nigeria and West Africa

Nature of harm: Communal violence, deaths, economic disruption, social fragmentation

In Nigeria, disinformation is a primary driver of ethno-religious tension between the predominantly Muslim north and Christian south. The Cunliffe-Jones database documents a case where a false WHO claim circulated that southern Nigerian beef was infected "to kill southerners" — entirely fabricated, with the potential to trigger boycotts, economic harm to northern Muslims, and severe discrimination. Peer-reviewed research published in the *RUDN Journal of Studies in Literature and Journalism* documents how "manufactured lies" have consistently deepened ethnic divisions between communities in Nigeria and Ghana, exploiting pre-existing fault lines. This builds on the BBC's finding during the 2013/2016 elections that

Cambridge Analytica used targeting techniques to amplify divisive content by ethnic community.^[18]^[1]^[^3]

In 2022, after the #EndSARS protests against police brutality, the Nigerian government deployed systematic disinformation labelling protesters as foreign stooges, which legitimised continued crackdowns and psychological harm to activists and their families.^[19]

2.3 Conflict-Zone Disinformation and Forced Displacement

Nature of harm: Mass civilian displacement; degradation of access to humanitarian aid

In conflict zones across the continent — Ethiopia/Tigray, South Sudan, DRC, Cameroon's Anglophone region — disinformation functions as a force multiplier for violence. In Ethiopia, both sides in the Tigray conflict weaponised social media with false images and videos, leaving civilians unable to identify safe routes or access services. Graphic images from unrelated conflicts were relabelled and circulated to stoke fear, hinder aid access, and recruit fighters. The Tigray conflict saw both sides gaslighting civilian populations, making it impossible to independently verify humanitarian conditions.^[^1]

In the DRC, false claims that UN peacekeepers (MONUSCO) were plundering natural resources — including a widely shared Facebook post claiming that locals found "sacks of cobalt being transported by a MONUSCO vehicle" — deepened civilian distrust in international aid and contributed to attacks on peacekeeping missions. As MONUSCO's head stated: "There was a campaign of disinformation, misinformation, and false rumours which created a breach of trust". This disinformation led to mob attacks on UN convoys in Goma, DRC, in which civilians were killed.^[^2]

Harm Category 3: Xenophobic Disinformation and Anti-Migrant Hate Speech

3.1 Africa-Wide Pattern

Nature of harm: Physical attacks, deaths, economic displacement of migrant communities

Anti-migrant disinformation is widespread across Africa, but has its most intense expression in South Africa, where it intersects with economic desperation, apartheid legacies, and deliberate political mobilisation. Across the continent, research shows that anti-immigrant attitudes are strongly correlated with *beliefs* — frequently false — that immigrants increase crime, take jobs, and strain resources. These beliefs are systematically amplified by political actors and social media, creating an epistemological trap where communities act on fabricated statistics.^[^20]

3.2 South Africa: The Most Documented Case

Nature of harm: Deaths, attacks on homes and businesses, denial of healthcare and education, diplomatic crises, psychological terror for migrant communities

South Africa has experienced waves of deadly xenophobic violence since 2008, when 62 people — including South Africans, Mozambicans, Zimbabweans, and Somalis — were killed.

Sporadic waves erupted in 2015, 2019, 2021–22, and most recently in April–May 2026, when vigilante groups affiliated with the March and March movement and Operation Dudula carried out violent attacks targeting African and Asian foreign nationals in Pretoria, Johannesburg, and Durban, with little apparent police response. In April 2026 alone, five Ethiopian nationals were killed in Johannesburg, including three shot inside a McDonald's restaurant.^{[21][22]}

The role of disinformation in this violence is structural and well-documented:

- **False statistical claims** about immigrant numbers: Africa Check has repeatedly debunked claims that one-third of Malawi's population had migrated to South Africa, that foreigners make up the majority of the prison population, and that immigrants are responsible for most unemployment.^[^23]
- **Fabricated atrocity content:** A graphic story published on the South African website Mzansi Live — claiming four foreign women were burned alive with their babies — was entirely false but shared more than 25,000 times on Facebook.^[^23]
- **Coordinated social media manipulation:** The Centre for Analytics and Behavioural Change (CABC) documented active coordinated attempts to manipulate xenophobia-centred conversations on South African social media.^[^24]
- **Hate speech by named activists:** Operation Dudula — whose leader the Johannesburg High Court confirmed had engaged in "the incitement of violence, the propagation of hate speech" — used social media platforms systematically to dehumanise migrants and direct followers to hospitals and schools to physically block foreign nationals from accessing services.^{[25][26]}
- **Denial of healthcare:** Operation Dudula activists were documented physically blocking foreign nationals from entering public clinics and hospitals before court interdict. A November 2025 High Court judgment confirmed that this constituted unlawful intimidation.^{[26][25]}

The 2026 wave brought a new information-complexity: the South African government publicly condemned "fake videos" being circulated online claiming attacks, while simultaneously, documented attacks were being filmed and verified by Human Rights Watch. This dual reality — real violence occurring alongside both real and fake documentation — illustrates the compounded difficulty of countering disinformation in live conflict situations.^{[27][22]}

Harm Category 4: Supernatural/Occult Disinformation and Ritual Violence

4.1 Attacks on People with Albinism

Nature of harm: Murder, mutilation, psychological terror, social exclusion

One of Africa's most extreme and persistent forms of disinformation-linked violence targets people with albinism. The false belief — propagated through traditional oral networks, amplified in some cases by fake social media content — that body parts of persons with albinism possess magical properties conferring wealth, electoral success, or fertility, has

driven an epidemic of killings and mutilations in East and Southern Africa. The UN CRPD Committee has documented a pattern of ritual killings and mutilations in Tanzania: over 170 recorded attacks, more than 80 murders since 2000, and a systematic spike around elections. In 2024, the UN Committee on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities condemned Tanzania's failure to act, finding it equivalent to "condoning ritual killings". Attacks have also been recorded in Mozambique, Malawi, DRC, and Burundi. In Tanzania, every election cycle produces a spike in killings as politicians seek ritual amulets made from albino body parts — attacks on children are especially common because they cannot resist.^{[28][29][30][31]}

In Mozambique, a related myth targets bald men, claiming their heads contain gold — documented cases of attacks on men with male-pattern baldness have been reported. In 2026, a child from Mozambique was among those found by Interpol to have been kidnapped for organ removal. In northern South Africa, a specific disinformation narrative — that albinism is contagious or causes bad luck — leads to severe social exclusion and forced separation of children from families.^{[32][33][34]}

4.2 Child Organ Harvesting Rumours Triggering Mob Violence

Nature of harm: Deaths and permanent injuries to innocent people accused

The Cunliffe-Jones database contains a high-scoring incident in which two medical researchers were killed and one permanently maimed by a mob acting on a completely false rumour that they were harvesting children's organs. This pattern — where false organ-harvesting rumours trigger immediate mob justice against innocent people — is well-documented across Africa and South Asia. In the DRC, false claims that health workers or aid agency staff were trafficking organs circulated repeatedly in conflict zones. The false beliefs are often amplified by local social media influencers or religious figures, and spread too rapidly for any correction to reach communities before violence occurs.^{[3][2]}

Harm Category 5: Gender Disinformation and Harmful Patriarchal Narratives

5.1 Disinformation Enabling Gender-Based Violence

Nature of harm: Physical violence, sexual assault, psychological harm, forced marriages

Disinformation intersects with gender-based harm through several mechanisms. First, false narratives about women's sexuality — claiming that HIV is spread exclusively by promiscuous women, or that "corrective rape" can cure lesbianism — legitimise violence against women. In South African townships, the well-documented practice of "corrective rape" targeting Black lesbians draws on an ideological framework reinforced by false religious narratives about homosexuality as a "Western disease" or a "curable" condition. The UK-based Roberts and Karekwaivanane book (2024) documents how misogynists systematically mobilised against the #AmINext campaign against gender-based violence in South Africa, using disinformation tactics to discredit survivors and delegitimise the movement.^{[34][35]}

In Ethiopia, UNESCO monitoring found that by mid-2025, gender-based hate speech had risen sharply, surpassing ethnic hate speech in volume and aggression against women online, with

direct spillover into offline harassment. The October 2024 spike in online incitement to violence in Ethiopia — coinciding with the Amhara conflict and the Irreecha festival — illustrates how gender and ethnic disinformation interact.^[36]

5.2 Menstrual Disinformation and Reproductive Health Falsehoods

Nature of harm: School dropout, poor health decisions, psychological harm

In many African communities, harmful myths and disinformation about menstruation — that it is a curse, that menstruating women contaminate food or water, that girls should not attend school during their period — cause girls to miss an estimated one to four days of school monthly. UNFPA estimates that one in ten sub-Saharan African girls misses school at some point during their period, with approximately seven million South African schoolgirls unable to afford sanitary products. Where girls lack accurate information about menstruation — because adults and schools reinforce harmful myths rather than providing health education — the consequences include school dropout, resort to dangerous hygiene alternatives (rags, leaves, newspapers), and vulnerability to exploitation. This is an under-reported dimension of disinformation harm that disproportionately affects girls in rural areas.^[37]^[38]

5.3 LGBTQ+ Disinformation and Hate Speech

Nature of harm: Physical violence, arbitrary arrest, social exclusion, psychological trauma

Across Africa, LGBTQ+ people face escalating disinformation-driven hostility. In 2023, Amnesty International documented a "surge in discriminatory legislation" across 12 African countries, with legal systems increasingly weaponised to target LGBTQ+ individuals. This legal weaponisation is driven by false narratives — widely circulated online and from religious pulpits — that homosexuality is a Western imposition, a mental illness, or a threat to children. In Uganda, the 2023 Anti-Homosexuality Act (which introduces the death penalty in some circumstances) was passed in a social environment saturated with these disinformation narratives. In Cameroon, over 30 cases of violence and abuse against LGBTQ+ people were recorded since 2022. In South Africa — the only African country with constitutional protections for sexual orientation — the ISD documented coordinated online gendered abuse and disinformation targeting LGBTQ+ people during the 2024 election, including "threats of offline violence including rape and death threats".^[39]^[40]^[41]^[42]

Harm Category 6: Agricultural and Climate Disinformation

6.1 Anti-Science Narratives About Climate Change

Nature of harm: Delayed adaptation, crop failures, livestock deaths, food insecurity

UNESCO has documented that in 2024, false narratives presenting climate change as a "Western concern" or conspiracy created "substantial barriers to local climate actions and adaptation strategies" across Africa, leaving communities unprepared for floods and droughts. People dismiss climate reports as "Western propaganda", making them less likely to take protective agricultural decisions. This is consequential given that approximately 80% of

the global population most at risk from crop failures due to climate change live in Sub-Saharan Africa, South Asia, and Southeast Asia. The World Bank projects that up to 43 million people in Africa could fall below the poverty line by 2030 as a direct result of climate change impacts on agriculture.^{[43][44]}

Research on smallholder farmers in South Africa's Eastern Cape found that only 24% had access to seasonal forecasts, with access to climate services producing statistically significant improvements in farming decisions including planting timing and crop selection — suggesting that disinformation that undermines trust in climate services has direct, measurable economic consequences.^[^45]

6.2 False Agricultural Advice and Disinformation About Inputs

Nature of harm: Crop failures, livestock deaths, economic loss for smallholders

A rapidly growing harm category is the spread of false agricultural advice through WhatsApp groups, Facebook, and local radio. Experts at the 2025 Africa Biennial Biosciences Communication symposium in Lusaka warned that "unchecked falsehoods risk undermining public trust, delaying innovation, and eroding the benefits of science-led solutions" in agriculture. This includes false claims about the dangers of genetically modified crops (blocking food-secure solutions), false advice about pesticide use or water management, and disinformation about drought-resistant seed programmes. The African Agriculture Technology Foundation (AATF) specifically named "misinformation and disinformation as emerging barriers to Africa's adoption of innovative biosciences". When farmers in drought-prone areas receive false information that a coming season will be normal — whether from social media speculation or from those with financial interests in maintaining false expectations — and do not take precautions, the consequences can include complete livestock and crop loss.^[^46]

Harm Category 7: Financial Disinformation, Fraud, and Scams

7.1 Fake Job Advertisements and Identity Fraud

Nature of harm: Financial loss, identity theft, psychological harm

The Cunliffe-Jones database specifically rates fake job advertisements as high-harm incidents: scammers place advertisements for nonexistent positions on social media, collect personal identification information from applicants, and use this data for identity theft and financial fraud. This crime exploits the severe unemployment crisis across Africa: with youth unemployment above 40% in South Africa, people are particularly susceptible to offers of employment. Scammers exploit urgency and hope to harvest CVs, identity documents, and banking details. The South African State of Scams 2025 report found that 77% of adults experienced a scam in the past year, with 42% losing money.^{[22][47][^3]}

7.2 Investment Fraud and Ponzi Schemes

Nature of harm: Total financial ruin for ordinary households

Investment fraud — particularly fake cryptocurrency platforms and Ponzi schemes promoted via social media — causes severe financial harm to ordinary Africans. Meta's own internal documents (disclosed in a Reuters investigation in 2025) estimate that the platform displays approximately 15 billion "high-risk" scam ads daily. A disproportionate share of these target vulnerable consumers in the Global South with promises of high cryptocurrency returns. South Africa's fraud losses approached three billion rand in 2025. The GSMA's Scam Signal initiative, launched in South Africa in October 2025, specifically targets Authorised Push Payment (APP) fraud, where victims are socially engineered into willingly transferring funds to fraudsters through fake urgency and impersonation of trusted institutions.^[48]^[49]

7.3 Romance Scams and "Pig Butchering"

Nature of harm: Financial ruin, psychological devastation, social stigma

Romance scams — where scammers build emotional relationships online and then extract money — cause devastating financial and psychological harm. "Pig butchering" scams, where targets are groomed over weeks or months before being introduced to fake investment platforms, are increasingly operating in Africa. WhatsApp is the primary vector in many cases, with near-zero traceability. The combination of financial loss and shame prevents many victims from reporting to authorities or seeking support.^[50]

7.4 Advance Fee and Impersonation Fraud (South Africa)

Nature of harm: Financial loss; identity theft; psychological exploitation

Advance fee fraud originating in Nigeria (419 scams) and increasingly South Africa (where two World Bank impersonation schemes have been documented) targets ordinary people with false promises of windfall cash payments or debt relief. Scammers impersonate the World Bank, SASSA (South Africa's social grants agency), or other trusted institutions. People who can least afford it — those desperate for income support — are most likely to respond to fraudulent SASSA payment notifications.^[51]

Harm Category 8: Disinformation About Public Services and Social Entitlements

Nature of harm: Denial of legitimate benefits; exploitation of the vulnerable

A less-documented but significant harm category involves false information about how to access public services — health, education, social grants, or utilities. In South Africa, false information about the Social Relief of Distress (SRD) grant, the Child Support Grant, and COVID-19 relief payments has been circulated by both scammers seeking to extract fees and by political actors seeking to discredit the government. The Cunliffe-Jones database contains an illuminating example: a false claim, initially published by mainstream South African media, that pregnant women were deliberately harming their babies to qualify for welfare benefits. This fabrication — which the database rates as causing cumulative gender and race

stereotyping with potential to incite abuse of mothers — illustrates how disinformation from *credible* media sources can reinforce harmful social stigma, leading to discrimination against mothers claiming legitimate support.[^3]

In the DRC, false claims about who qualifies for food aid from organisations such as WFP have been circulated in conflict zones, both as disruptive disinformation by armed groups seeking to undermine civilian trust in international aid, and as scam operations targeting displaced people.[^2]

Summary Matrix: Harm Categories and Their Characteristics

Harm Category	Primary Harm Type	Reach	Velocity to Harm	South Africa Specific Severity
1a. Fake cures / miracle healing	Death (treatment abandonment)	Continent-wide	Slow (weeks–months)	HIGH — ARV abandonment well-documented
1b. Disease rumours → mob violence	Death (health workers killed)	Central/East Africa	Very fast (hours–days)	MODERATE
1c. Anti-vaccine disinformation	Preventable deaths (measles, polio)	Continent-wide	Medium	MODERATE
2a. False ethnic violence footage	Deaths, retaliatory violence	Conflict zones	Very fast	MODERATE (via xenophobia)
2b. Ethno-religious hate speech	Communal violence	West Africa primarily	Medium	LOW (different fault lines)
3. Xenophobic disinformation	Deaths, denial of services	Southern Africa	Fast	VERY HIGH — ongoing 2026
4a. Albinism myths	Murder, mutilation	East/Southern Africa	Seasonal (election spikes)	LOW-MODERATE (N. SA)
4b. Organ harvesting rumours	Mob killings of innocents	Sub-Saharan Africa	Very fast	MODERATE
5a. Gender/LGBTQ hate speech	Physical violence, rape	Continent-wide	Medium	HIGH — documented 2024–26
5b. Menstrual disinformation	Education disruption, health harm	Rural Africa	Chronic	HIGH — rural and township
6a. Climate denialism	Food insecurity, livestock loss	Sub-Saharan Africa	Slow (seasonal)	MODERATE-HIGH (farming)
7a. Job scam / ID fraud	Financial loss, identity theft	Continent-wide	Fast	VERY HIGH — 77% scam rate
7b. Investment / romance fraud	Financial ruin	Urban Africa	Medium-fast	VERY HIGH — R3bn+ losses
8. Benefits disinformation	Denial of rights, exploitation	Where social grants exist	Medium	HIGH — SASSA scams

Cross-Cutting Observations

1. Offline amplification multiplies harm beyond the digital sphere. False information originating online consistently leaps to radio, community meetings, churches, and word-of-mouth. In Mali, Jamie Hitchen has documented how a tweet read by 10% of the population can reach 100% of the population via radio. This cross-platform amplification is the defining transmission mechanism for African information harm.^[^2]

2. Religious authority is the most dangerous amplifier. Across health, gender, and conflict categories, religious leaders function as the critical "last mile" amplifier of false information. When a pastor declares someone healed of HIV, burns their medication, and takes money for the blessing, the harm is immediate and fatal. When a pastor in DRC spreads a rumour about a fake disease from the pulpit, four health workers die. Strategies that do not engage faith communities are incomplete.^{[14][1]}

3. The harm-speed paradox favours disinformation. Viral false videos travel in seconds; fact-checks take hours at minimum, and most are only accessible to the online-connected minority. In reprisal-violence situations, the window between a false claim and the first fatality can be measured in hours.^[^2]

4. Economic desperation is the meta-driver. Across almost every harm category — fake jobs, miracle cures, investment fraud, political manipulation — the enabling condition is economic desperation. People seek cures they can afford; people respond to job ads because they desperately need work; people join armed groups because they have no income. Disinformation exploits this desperation systematically.^[^1]

5. South Africa's harm profile is distinctive but not unique. South Africa faces the full complement of harm categories but at different intensities than the rest of the continent. Xenophobic violence and financial fraud are the most severe categories; faith-based health disinformation (particularly around HIV/ART) is significant; agricultural and conflict-zone disinformation are lower-intensity than in fragile states. The critical South Africa-specific risk is the combination of high social media penetration, a large migrant population, high unemployment, and a well-organised infrastructure for promoting hate speech through platforms that the courts have had to intervene to restrict.^{[25][26]}

This report has drawn on: the Cunliffe-Jones Africa fact-check incident database; Alphonse Shiundu's chapter on disinformation in Africa (2026); "Disinformation and Peacebuilding in Sub-Saharan Africa" (UNU-CPR, 2024); Roberts & Karekwaivanane, "Digital Disinformation in Africa" (Bloomsbury, 2024); and independent research from WHO, UNESCO, Human Rights Watch, Reuters, Africa Check, Amnesty International, UNAIDS, and other primary sources cited throughout.^{[52][19][1][3][^2]}

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